

THREE RIDERS • TWO DAYS • ONE COLD NIGHT

ADVENTURE BIKE GETAWAY

Mann River campground, Mann River Nature Reserve NSW

Saturday 29 – Sunday 30 August 2026 • Sites 13, 14 & 15

Lions Road and the Clarence Way in • Old Grafton Road out, conditions permitting

SATURDAY

≈490 km
Cornubia → Camp

OVERNIGHT LOW

0–3 °C
Frost likely

WATER AT CAMP

None
Carry all of it

SUNDAY

Plan A or B
Decided at camp

THE WEEKEND IN ONE PARAGRAPH

Saturday runs south – Mt Lindesay Highway to Rathdowney, Lions Road over the border to Kyogle, then **west** at Casino onto the Bruxner and down the Clarence Way through Baryulgil, Eighteen Mile and Copmanhurst to Grafton for lunch, and finally the Gwydir Highway up into the tablelands. The campground sits at the bottom of Big Hill, so the last leg is a steep descent off the highway with gravel at either end. It will be cold, dry and very dark. Sunday you make one decision over coffee: the 130 km of unsealed Old Grafton Road east to Grafton, or the sealed loop through Glen Innes and Tenterfield.

THE TWO THAT MATTER MOST

Fire. The Bush Fire Danger Period began in the Glen Innes Severn area on **1 August 2026**, two months early, and there is an active fire alert near the reserve. Assume no campfire; every rider carries a stove.

Gravel. The Clarence Way is **not** sealed end to end – Clarence Valley Council reports ≈25 km unsealed between Copmanhurst and its boundary. Fine on these bikes; damp clay in the cuttings.



Drawn to scale from surveyed town coordinates. Road alignments are simplified – a planning diagram, not a navigation chart.

01 SATURDAY – CORNUBIA TO MANN RIVER

≈490 km | 7½ hours moving | allow 10 hours door to door. Meet **06:00**, roll 06:15. Fuel at **Kyogle, Grafton and Jackadgery**, plus a top-up at Casino. NSW and Queensland run on the same time in August.

TIME	LEG	DIST.	NOTES
06:00	Cornubia – 7-Eleven, 1905 Pacific Hwy	–	Fill every tank. Pressures, brief. Wheels rolling 06:15.
07:20	Beaudesert (Mt Lindesay Hwy)	48 km	Roll through.
07:45	Rathdowney – coffee and regroup	27 km	No fuel needed. Stretch, then straight into the good bit.
09:50	FUEL 1 Kyogle – via Lions Road	85 km	BP, 160 km on the tank. Lions Road is sealed, narrow and superb – potholes, timber bridges, greasy cattle grids.
10:40	TOP-UP Casino – onto the Bruxner Hwy	33 km	Ollie splashes here – no longer optional. Makes the run to Grafton 158 km instead of 191. Turn west on the Bruxner, not south.
13:05	FUEL 2 Grafton – via the Clarence Way	158 km	Bruxner west ≈38 km to Sandilands, then the Clarence Way ≈120 km through Baryulgil, Eighteen Mile and Copmanhurst – ≈25 km unsealed. Lunch booked at the Crown, 1 Prince St, 02 6642 4000. 45 min.
14:35	FUEL 3 Jackadgery (Gwydir Hwy)	50 km	Last fuel. Mann River Caravan Park, 8am–5pm off season, 02 6647 4662. You arrive with 2½ hours in hand, not four. Ring on the Friday.
15:30	Gibraltar Range → Old Grafton Rd turnoff	75 km	Long climb through the range. Turnoff is 125 km west of Grafton.
16:00	CAMP Mann River campground	16 km	Turnoff at 476 km. ≈2 km gravel, 14 km of steep sealed descent down Big Hill, 150 m to camp. Sunset 5:38pm.

Distances are planning estimates. Grafton→turnoff (125 km) and turnoff→camp (16 km) follow NPWS figures; the Clarence Way legs and the rest are approximate. Confirm in your own navigation.

FUEL – OLLIE'S TANK PLUS THE BLADDER

Assume **220 km usable** on Ollie's bike, not 250, and ≈100 km from the 8 L bladder.

LEG	DIST.	MARGIN
Cornubia → Kyogle	160 km	60 km
Kyogle → Casino (top-up)	33 km	187 km
Casino → Grafton	158 km	62 km
Grafton → Jackadgery	50 km	170 km
Jackadgery → camp	91 km	129 km
Camp → Grafton (Plan A)	130 km	80 km

Why the Casino top-up. The Clarence Way makes Kyogle→Grafton 191 km, leaving Ollie 29 km. That is too thin. Thirty-three kilometres after a fill feels silly, but it is what makes the route work. Simon and Dave can skip it.

THE CLARENCE WAY – AND THE GRAVEL IN IT

The Summerland Way from Casino to Grafton through Whiporie is dead straight and, in Dave's words, the most monotonous road he has ridden. The Clarence Way follows the river valley instead – winding, hilly and quiet, through Baryulgil, Eighteen Mile and Copmanhurst.

Not fully sealed. Clarence Valley Council reports **14.01 km unsealed** between Copmanhurst and Baryulgil and **10.84 km** between Baryulgil and its boundary – ≈25 km of gravel. Fine on these bikes, but damp clay in the shaded cuttings after Wednesday's rain.

It costs ≈48 km and about an hour, which is why you meet at 06:00. **Bail-out:** late at Casino, or closures on Live Traffic – turn south on the Summerland Way, camp by 15:00, and subtract 48 km from every marker after Casino.

ARRIVAL ROUTINE

Sunset 5:38pm and the valley walls take it earlier. Camp by 16:00 leaves about 1½ hours – enough, but not generous. This is what the Clarence Way costs.

02 MANN RIVER CAMPGROUND

Mann River Nature Reserve, 37 km east of Glen Innes on the Old Grafton Road. Riverside, remote, 15 sites. You have 13, 14 and 15.

THE FACTS	
Reserve	Mann River Nature Reserve, NPWS Northern Tablelands
Sites	15 marked, unpowered sites
Cost	No camping fee; \$6 booking fee
Toilets	Non-flush. No showers.
Water	None. Bring drinking and cooking water.
Cooking	Free gas/electric barbecues and a large picnic shelter; wood barbecues at sites
Firewood	Not supplied. Collecting it in the reserve is prohibited.
Reception	Limited to none
Not allowed	Pets, smoking, gathering firewood
Contacts	NPWS Glen Innes 02 6739 0700 NPWS bookings 1300 072 757

Source: NSW National Parks, Mann River campground and picnic area, checked 9 August 2026.

FIRE STATUS – CHECK THIS BEFORE YOU PACK

The NSW RFS brought the **Bush Fire Danger Period** forward to **1 August 2026** for the Glen Innes Severn, Tenterfield and Inverell areas because the Northern Tablelands is exceptionally dry. A fire alert named the **Mann River Fire** has been active nearby since late July.

A campfire in the provided fireplace is normally still allowed during the danger period, but a **Total Fire Ban would rule it out entirely** – and bans are declared at short notice. Check RFS on the Friday and again from Grafton if you have signal.

Plan on gas. If the fire happens, treat it as a bonus rather than the dinner plan. If you do want one, buy a bag of firewood in Grafton or Glen Innes – three of you can carry one bag between you.

WATER MATHS

Three riders, one night, no tap. Budget **5 L per person** – drinking, coffee, dinner, breakfast and washing up. That is 15 L, or 5 kg each, which is very manageable in a soft collapsible container plus a 1 L bottle on the bike.

The river is right there for washing up and rinsing. Carry purification tablets or a small filter as backup for cooking water only – not as your primary supply.

THE COLD NIGHT – WHAT ACTUALLY KEEPS YOU WARM

NPWS records a winter range for the reserve of roughly **0.7 °C to 14 °C**, with a lowest recorded temperature of **-8.3 °C**. Late August in a river valley on the edge of the tablelands, under the clear dry sky this season is delivering, means **frost is a realistic expectation**, not a worst case. Clear skies make it colder, not warmer.

THE THREE THAT DO 90% OF THE WORK

1. The mat, not the bag. Most cold nights are lost to the ground, not the air. You want an insulated mat with an **R-value of 4 or better**. A summer foam mat under a good bag will still leave you awake at 3am.

2. A bag with a comfort rating near -5 °C. Comfort rating, not "extreme" – the extreme figure is a survival number, not a sleep number. A liner adds a few degrees cheaply and packs small.

3. Dry clothes. Get out of riding gear the moment the tent is up. Damp base layers will undo everything else. Sleep in clean thermals, dry socks and a beanie.

THE SMALL THINGS THAT MAKE THE DIFFERENCE

Hot water bottle. Boil the billy last thing, fill a hard bottle, put it in the foot of the bag. Costs nothing and works remarkably well.

Eat properly and late. A decent hot dinner is fuel for the night's shivering budget.

The ground is crushed rock. Standard pegs can struggle. Bring solid pegs, and a freestanding tent is a real advantage.

Frost on everything by morning. Seats, tents and the first few kilometres of road. Put anything you need dry – gloves, boots, electronics – inside the tent overnight.

SUNDAY MORNING: THE COLDEST RIDING OF THE TRIP

Plan B climbs Big Hill. Fourteen kilometres of steep, shaded, sealed road back up to the Gwydir Highway in single-digit temperatures. After a frost, expect ice in the shadowed corners and damp patches that have not seen the sun. Brake early and let the tyres warm up.

Plan A does not. It heads the other way, east along Old Grafton Road at river level – so no climb, but you start on frosted gravel while you and the bikes are still cold. Same discipline, different surface.

03 SUNDAY – TWO WAYS HOME

One decision, made over coffee before you break camp. Plan A is the adventure ride. Plan B is the shorter, faster, sealed alternative – and a genuinely good day.

GO / NO-GO FOR OLD GRAFTON ROAD – ALL FIVE MUST BE YES

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Dry for several days, and no rain overnight | ☐ Everyone genuinely happy with 130 km of remote gravel |
| ☐ No rain in Sunday's forecast for the Clarence Valley | ☐ Ollie fuelled at Jackadgery and carrying the bladder , away by 08:00 |
| ☐ No closures on Live Traffic NSW or NPWS alerts | |

Anything less than a clear yes on all five – take Plan B. Old Grafton Road has been there since 1867 and will still be there next time.

PLAN A OLD GRAFTON ROAD – DRY CONDITIONS ONLY

≈430 km | 7-8 hrs Camp → Old Grafton Road → Grafton → Pacific Highway → home

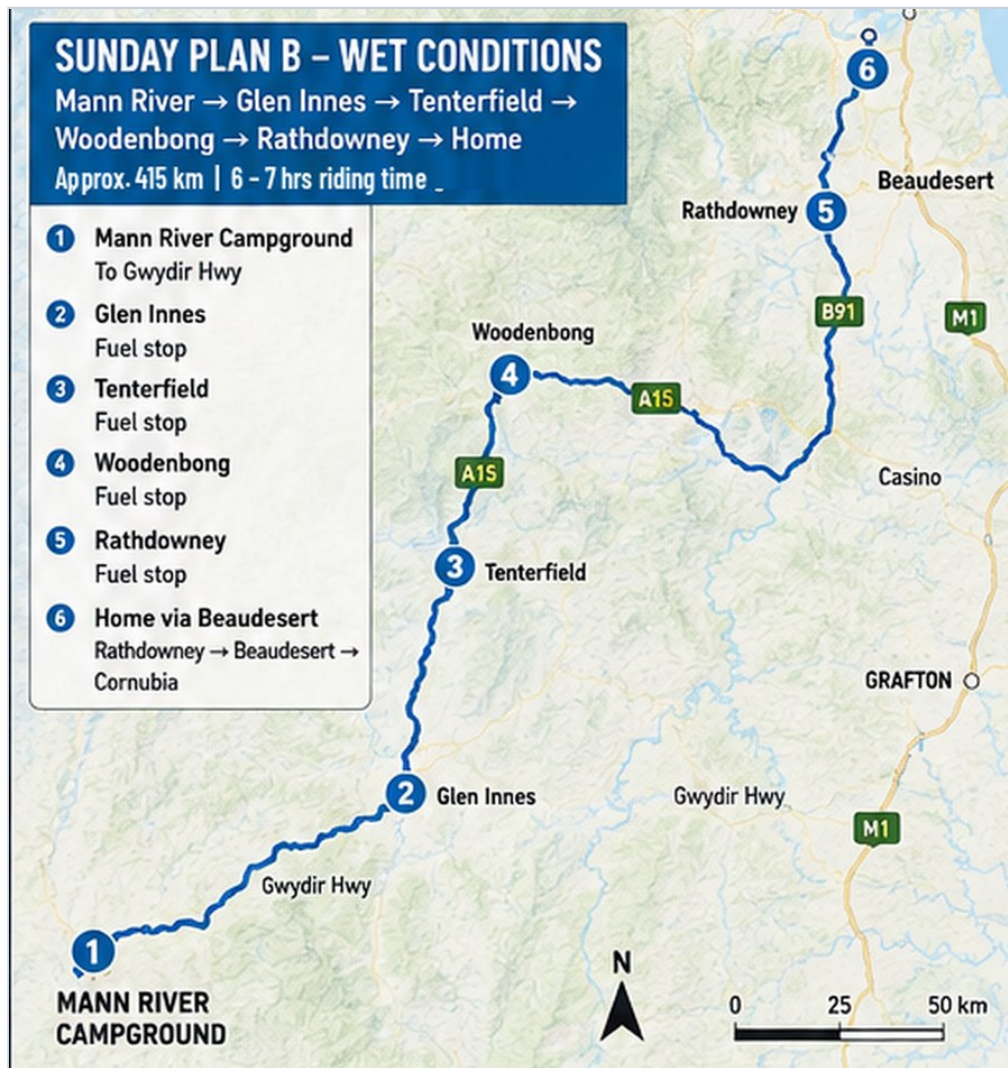


- **≈130 km unsealed** camp to Grafton, allow 3½–4½ hours. Corrugations, loose gravel, one-lane sections, river crossings and blind corners.
- Highlights: the hand-carved 1880s tunnel east of Dalmorton, the village itself, and the Boyd and Nymboida river country.

- **No fuel, no services, no reception** for the entire 130 km. Head east out of camp at river level – this way does **not** climb Big Hill.
- Then ≈300 km of Pacific Highway home, with fuel and a leg stretch at Ballina and again near Tweed.

PLAN B GLEN INNES AND TENTERFIELD – WET, OR ANY DOUBT

≈415 km | 6-7 hrs Camp → Glen Innes → Tenterfield → Woodenbong → Rathdowney → home



- **Shorter and quicker than Plan A**, entirely sealed, and a completely different route home from Saturday's.
- Glen Innes **53 km** (16 km up Big Hill to the highway, then 37 km west) → Tenterfield 87 km → Woodenbong ≈110 km → Rathdowney ≈90 km → Beaudesert → Cornubia.
- **Fuel at Tenterfield and Woodenbong.** Woodenbong to home is ≈165 km, the longest leg of the day and inside Ollie's range.
- The Mt Lindesay Highway from Tenterfield to Woodenbong is high, quiet and one of the better roads in the region. Not a compromise.

COLD START, WHICHEVER YOU PICK

Plan B climbs Big Hill – 14 km of steep, shaded, sealed road in single-digit temperatures. After a frost, expect ice in the shadowed corners. **Plan A does not climb**, but starts straight onto frosted gravel while you and the bikes are cold. Brake early either way, and let the tyres warm up.

NUMBERS WORTH HAVING WRITTEN DOWN

Emergency – 000 (limited reception; use Emergency+ or the satellite messenger)

NPWS Glen Innes – 02 6739 0700

NPWS bookings – 1300 072 757

NSW RFS bush fire information – 1800 679 737

Live Traffic NSW – 132 701

Mann River Caravan Park, Jackadgery – 02 6647 4662

IF YOU SPLIT THE GROUP

Don't. But if two want Plan A and one wants Plan B, agree a check-in time and an "if you haven't heard from me by" time *before* anyone leaves camp. There is no reception to sort it out later.

04 PACKING LIST – CAMP

Per rider unless marked. Three bikes, one cold night, no water and possibly no fire. **Bold = do not leave without it.**

SLEEP SYSTEM	THE PART THAT DECIDES THE TRIP	WATER	THERE IS NONE AT THE CAMPGROUND
☐ Sleeping bag, comfort rating $\approx -5^{\circ}\text{C}$		☐ 5 L drinking/cooking water per person (15 L total)	
☐ Insulated mat, R-value 4+ (ground cold is the enemy)		☐ Collapsible 4–5 L container + 1 L bottle	
☐ Bag liner — cheap extra warmth, packs tiny		☐ Purification tablets or small filter (backup only)	
☐ Inflatable or stuff-sack pillow			
☐ Thermals to sleep in (clean and dry, kept for sleeping only)			
☐ Dry socks for the bag			
☐ Beanie — you lose a lot through your head			
☐ Hot water bottle / hard-sided drink bottle			

SHELTER		COOKING & FOOD	ASSUME NO CAMPFIRE
☐ Tent with a full fly (freestanding is best on gravel)		☐ Gas stove + full canister (group: two stoves, three canisters)	
☐ Footprint or groundsheet		☐ Lighter and matches in a waterproof bag	
☐ Solid pegs — ground is crushed rock		☐ Pot or pan, mug, bowl, spork (per person)	
☐ Guy lines (frost and valley wind)		☐ Sharp knife, tongs, small chopping board (group)	
☐ Small brush or cloth to wipe frost off in the morning		☐ Tea towel, scourer, biodegradable soap	
☐ Bike cover or tarp (group: one or two is plenty)		☐ Saturday dinner — something hot and substantial	
☐ Camp chair — the single best luxury per gram		☐ Sunday breakfast — porridge or similar, plus coffee	
		☐ Snacks for the road: nuts, jerky, muesli bars, chocolate	
		☐ Electrolytes or cordial (you drink less when cold and still dehydrate)	
		☐ Rubbish bags — everything you bring in comes out	
		☐ Optional: firewood from Grafton or Glen Innes (group: one bag)	

CAMP CLOTHING	PACKED DRY, WORN DRY
☐ Insulated jacket — down or synthetic puffer	
☐ Fleece or mid layer	
☐ Warm trousers or thermal leggings	
☐ Camp shoes (boots off is worth the space)	
☐ Warm gloves for camp, separate from riding gloves	
☐ Buff or neck warmer	
☐ Change of clothes for Sunday	
☐ Small towel	
☐ Toiletries, toilet paper, hand sanitiser	
☐ Sunscreen and lip balm (cold, dry and high — it catches people out)	

LIGHT & POWER
☐ Head torch + spare batteries
☐ Small lantern (group: one)
☐ Power bank, 10,000 mAh+ (cold flattens phones fast)
☐ Charging cables for phone, GPS, intercom
☐ Phone in a pocket inside your jacket overnight, not in the tent porch

05 PACKING LIST – BIKE, SAFETY & GROUP

Three bikes means you do not each need one of everything. Split the heavy shared items and tell each other who has what.

RIDING GEAR

DRESS FOR THE DESCENT, NOT THE DEPARTURE

☐ Thermal base layer, top and bottom

☐ Mid layer / fleece under the jacket

☐ Windproof outer and rain liner

☐ Winter gloves + a spare dry pair

☐ Neck tube, balaclava or buff

☐ Clear or light-tint visor (early starts, shaded valleys)

☐ Anti-fog treatment or Pinlock insert

☐ Waterproof over-gloves and over-boots

☐ Earplugs

☐ Heated grips or vest – if fitted, check they work before you go

BIKE PREP & TOOLS

PER BIKE UNLESS MARKED

☐ Tyres checked and pressures set for the load

☐ Chain adjusted and lubed; small bottle of lube

☐ Oil and coolant levels; lights and brakes checked

☐ Tubeless plug kit or tube to suit your wheels

☐ Compact compressor or CO₂ (group: at least two)

☐ Tyre levers, rim protectors and spare levers (group)

☐ Basic tool roll to fit your bike, plus a multi-tool

☐ Zip ties, gaffer tape, wire, spare fasteners

☐ Tow strap and jump pack (group: one each)

☐ Luggage straps and dry bags – check nothing is rubbing the exhaust

SAFETY & COMMS

THERE IS NO PHONE RECEPTION OUT THERE

☐ Satellite messenger or PLB (group: at least one, ideally two)

☐ First aid kit (group: one comprehensive, plus a small personal one)

☐ Personal medications, clearly labelled, told to the others

☐ Emergency+ app installed on every phone

☐ Offline maps downloaded – **the whole route**

☐ Paper backup of the route and this guide

☐ Intercoms charged and paired

☐ Emergency blanket or bivvy bag

☐ Insect repellent

☐ Whistle (carries further than a shout)

DOCUMENTS & ADMIN

☐ Licence, registration, insurance details

☐ Campground booking confirmation – sites 13, 14, 15

☐ Roadside assistance membership number

☐ Emergency contact and medical details in your wallet

☐ Cash – small country stops are not always reliable on card

☐ Trip plan and return time left with someone at home

GROUP GEAR – DECIDE WHO CARRIES WHAT

RIDER

CARRIES

Bike 1

Stoves and gas, cooking kit, lantern

Bike 2

First aid, satellite comms, tow strap, jump pack

Bike 3

Compressor, tyre repair, spare tools, firewood if taken

Everyone still carries their own water, sleeping system, food and a basic tool roll.

THE WEEKEND, IN SHORT

Lions Road and the Clarence Way in. Last fuel at Jackadgery. Fifteen litres of water between you. A cold, clear, dark night with a stove and possibly no fire. Then Old Grafton Road out if it is genuinely dry, and the Glen Innes loop if it isn't. Simple enough – right up until someone produces a camp chair and starts offering route advice.

Verified 9 August 2026 against NSW National Parks and Wildlife Service, NSW Rural Fire Service, and Kyogle and Clarence Valley Council road information. Corrected from the earlier draft: reserve name, no water at the campground, Lions Road is sealed, campground access is not fully sealed, Old Grafton Road ≈130 km, Sunday Plan A ≈430 km, Plan B ≈415 km (camp to Glen Innes is 53 km, not 37 – the 37 km NPWS figure is highway-only and excludes the 16 km down Big Hill). Saturday now fuels at Jackadgery rather than diverting to Glen Innes (on the basis of Ollie's 8 L bladder), and runs Casino to Grafton via the Bruxner Highway and Clarence Way rather than the Summerland Way. The Saturday map has been redrawn from surveyed town coordinates. Ring Jackadgery on the Friday. Re-check alerts and fire bans before departure. Maps are planning diagrams, not navigation charts.

Adventure Bike Getaway • Mann River Nature Reserve • 29–30 August 2026

7 / 7